2026 Betclic Elite (LNB) predictions based on Statistical Analytics Models

AUEB & ENSAI Research Group

Athens University of Economics and Business and ENSAI University of Rennes

This article was edited and co-authored by ***Ioannis Ntzoufras****, Professor of Statistics at AUEB,* ***Argyro Damoulaki****, PhD Candidate in the same department and* ***Antoine Rustenholz****, who is doing an internship in the same department and comes from the University École Nationale de la Statistique et de l'Analyse de l'Information in Rennes (France).*

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The time has come for the two best French basketball teams of the 2025-26 season to battle for the title in a best-of-5 series. On the one hand, Paris Basketball dominated the regular season in terms of points scored. On the other hand, AS Monaco finished the season with the best sporting record (23 wins compared to 22 for Paris). However, a financial sanction imposed by the LNB resulted in a deduction of one win for Monaco. As a result, Paris secured first place in the official administrative standings and earned home-court advantage for the finals. The two teams have already faced each other in the finals over the past two years, with each team winning one title.

Reminder for friends of Statistics

The predictions in this article are based on a simple statistical approach (Vanilla Model), which relies exclusively on the results of competition matches to estimate team performance. The model does not use external information, such as betting company odds or rankings, but only team identity and historical performance, including results from the previous season - given that the team roster did not change radically, especially among the finalists. The chances of winning are derived through statistical modelling and repeated simulations of the matches. While no model can predict the outcome of a match with certainty, this approach provides an objective assessment of each team's odds based on the available data.

The model used in the following analysis has been trained on 2024-25 and 2025-26 seasons to provide more reliable estimates.

Review of the first two games

AS Monaco defied expectations by winning the second match with a commanding 12-point margin. They overcame the home-court advantage to get an important victory on Paris Basketball's home court.

Table 1: Comparison between actual outcomes and predicted odds for the matches already played.

Game	Home team	True outcome	Odds		Prevailing score difference (probability)
			Victory Home	Victory Away	
1	Paris Basketball	+4	0.740	0.260	+6 (0.031)
2	AS Monaco	-12	0.680	0.320	+6 (0.030)

Predictions for the next games

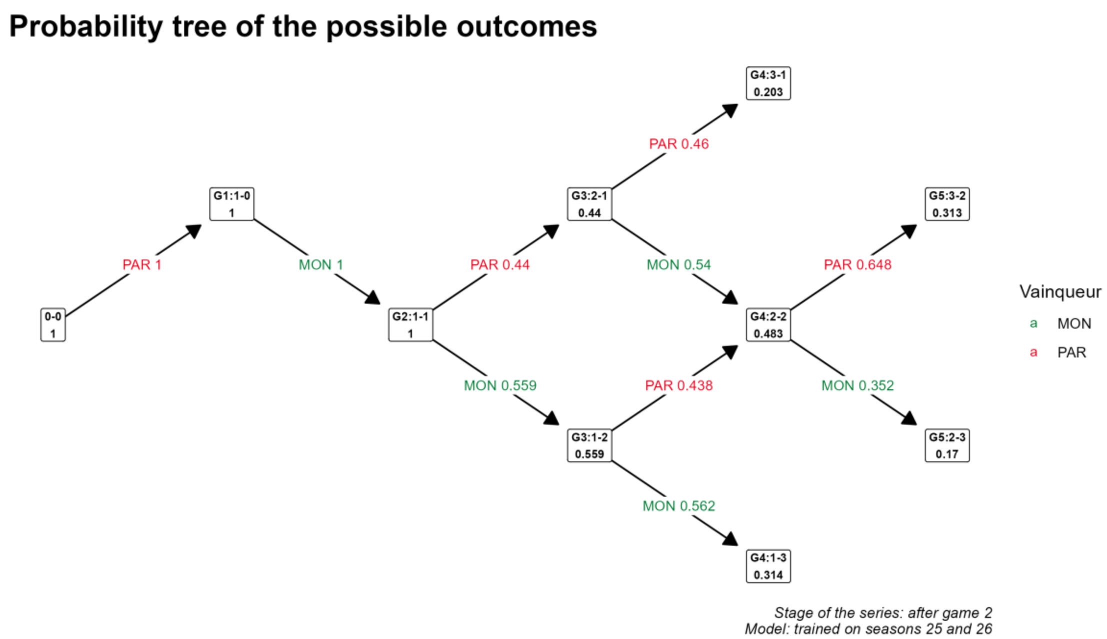
AS Monaco's unexpected victory on Paris Basketball's home court reshapes the predictions. With Games 3 and 4 now scheduled in Monaco, their overall win probability rises from 22.0% after game 2 to 48.4%. At this stage, the model gives Paris Basketball a narrow edge, with a 51.6% probability of winning the series.

Table 2: Odds of the outcome of the matches of the 2026 Betclic Elite Finals.

Game	Home team	Odds		Prevailing score difference (probability)	Probability for the game to be played
		Victory Home	Victory Away		
3	AS Monaco	0.559	0.441	+2 (0.032)	1.000
4	AS Monaco	0.552	0.448	+2 (0.027)	1.000
5	Paris Basketball	0.648	0.352	+5 (0.031)	0.483

To be more precise, here are the odds of the different possible scenarios of the final series, given the results of the first two games. The two most likely outcomes are a 3–2 Paris victory (31.3%) and a 3–1 Monaco victory (31.4%), making them roughly equally probable.

Figure 1: Probability tree of all possible scenarios of the 2026 Betclic Elite Finals.



The Magic Equations of the Statistical Model

[INSERER LES EQUATIONS MATHEMATIQUES DES MODELES]

$$Y_g = \mu + \alpha_{h(g)} - \alpha_{a(g)} + \varepsilon_g \quad , \qquad \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma^2)$$

subject to the identification contraint

$$\alpha_{\text{PAR}} = 0$$

where:

- Y_g denotes the score difference in game g, calculated as the home team's score minus the away team's score.
- μ is the global home advantage, common to all teams.
- $h(g)$ denotes the team playing at home in game g.
- $a(g)$ denotes the team playing away in game g.
- α_i is the single ability coefficient associated with team i, shared across home and away appearances.
- The constraint $\alpha_{\text{PAR}} = 0$ ensures identifiability by setting Paris Basketball as the reference team.
- ε_g is the random error term, assumed to follow a normal distribution with mean zero and variance σ^2.

The expected score difference for a game between home team $h(g)$ and away team $a(g)$ is

$$\mathbb{E}(Y_g) = \mu + \alpha_{h(g)} - \alpha_{a(g)}$$

The research team of the Athens University of Economics and Business AUEB Sports Analytics Group was founded in 2015 by Professors Ioannis Ntzoufras and Dimitris Karlis. Its members are important members of the sports analytics community such as Leonardo Egidi (University of Trieste), Ioannis Kosmidis (Warwick), Konstantinos Pelehrinis (Pittsburgh), Nial Friel (UCD) and Gianluca Baio (UCL) as well as the former coach of the Greek National Volleyball Team, Sotiris Drikos and the scouter of the Sacramento Kings, Christos Marmarinos. The research team is responsible for the series of annual conferences called AUEB Sports Analytics Workshop (6 in total) and in 2019 organized the international conference MathSport 2019 with 200 participating scientists from all over the world. The team has a number of important scientific publications in the field of sports analytics. Finally, we would like to mention that the team was founded in 2015 due to the visit of Professor Stefan Kesenne (University of Antwerp & Leuven), a great Sports Economist who also played an active role in the Bosman case. Stefan Kesenne actively supported the team until 2021 when he suddenly passed away. The existence of the AUEB Sports Analytics Group is largely due to the contribution and inspiration given to us by Mr. Kesenne.

Group website: https://aueb-analytics.wixsite.com/sports

Listen to the podcast on Basketball Analytics by Ioannis Ntzoufras, Argyro Damoulaki and Christos Marmarinos here.

A few words about the Authors

Ioannis Ntzoufras is Professor of Statistics and Chairman of the Department of Statistics of the Athens University of Economics and Business. He is a founding member of AUEB Sports Analytics Group along with Dimitris Karlis. He has recognized scientific activity in areas such as Bayesian statistical methodology, computational statistics, biostatistics, psychometrics and sports analytics.

Argyro Damoulaki is a PhD candidate at the Department of Statistics of AUEB. Her current research focuses on performance evaluation models using Bayesian statistics. She is involved in sports analytics and has been an active member of AUEB Sports Analytics Group since 2022.

Antoine Rustenholz is a fourth-year student (Engineering Degree) in Statistics at the École Nationale de la Statistique et de l'Analyse de l'Information, University of Rennes, France. He carries out his internship as a sports data analyst at the Computational and Bayesian Statistics Lab of the Department of Statistics and at the AUEB Sports Analytics Group.